



Forced return

A Pathet Lao soldier orders a group of Meo hill people to return to their homes following an attempt by the Meos to march to the Laotian capital to protest against repression by the new communist-led government in May 1975.

Re-education

The Hmong were not the only people to suffer under the new Laotian government. Thousands of both Lao and Hmong were imprisoned for up to ten years in so-called “re-education” camps similar to those in Vietnam, located in remote areas. About 10 percent of the population, including most among the business, professional, and educated classes fled the country. Nevertheless, the US State Department’s annual report on human rights violations did not mention Laos in 1976, 1977, or 1978. In 1979, the report noted some improvements in human rights in the preceding two years and rejected the charge of genocide, downplaying torture in the re-education camps. It reported evidence but not “absolute proof” of chemical warfare against the Hmong.